

3, For a Civil Society, the Most Crucial Element is That the People Possess Basic Common Sense

I believe this is because the Chinese lack "common sense" (常识)—which is, in itself, an exceedingly fascinating issue.

Do the Chinese lack *knowledge*? Actually, they do not. The popularization of compulsory education in China is quite impressive on a global scale, and for the urban middle class (*if such a class truly exists*), the per capita educational attainment is quite substantial.

But herein lies the sinister brilliance of Chinese education: it will indeed teach students specialized professional knowledge that they will almost never use in daily life, **yet it absolutely will not teach the common sense that is widely applicable in daily life and helps people instantly distinguish right from wrong**. Official education will systematically try every possible means to mislead the educated.

In reality, the "common sense" of the Chinese people is incredibly bizarre. If one resides in China for a prolonged period, it is not difficult to discover that the following ideologies are overwhelmingly pervasive and virtually unquestionable among our people:

- *Unification is always superior to division, regardless of the cost, and regardless of whether unification brings social progress or regression.*
- *State sovereignty supersedes human rights.* (They are completely ignorant of the concept of popular sovereignty [主权在民], believing that no matter what horrific, anti-human atrocities a government commits against its own people, other nations have absolutely no grounds to intervene).
- *Might makes right.* (Even though our government internationally appears capable of nothing but issuing verbal protests, the Chinese commoners still firmly believe that as long as a nation is powerful, it can violate international norms at will...)

Of course, citing the above three political concepts is already giving the Chinese people a lot of face. While these viewpoints are "wrong," they are at least not *"not even wrong."*

However, the ideologies held by the vast majority of Chinese people are truly impossible to even evaluate. For example, the daily barrage of absurd gibberish (满纸荒唐言)—such as "the imperial court is playing a grand chess game" (朝廷下大棋) or "the state relies on precise calculations of massive datasets" (海量数据精确计算)—sounds utterly ridiculous even to native Chinese speakers. If a foreigner were to observe this, they would find it completely incomprehensible.

Based on my observations from living in China year-round, the average cognitive level of the Chinese people today probably ranks near the very bottom among the 200-plus countries and regions in the world. **One could even argue that it is inferior to that of primitive tribes still in the hunter-gatherer stage.**

This is because, after enduring over ten centuries of **restoration-bureaucratic rule**, the Chinese have universally lost the capacities that can be defined as "human intelligence" (人类的智能). Their brains are generally incapable of establishing even the most fundamental logical connections between phenomena. This is an extraordinarily astonishing fact.

For instance, if we observe the tribesmen active in the northern taiga (boreal forests), it is not hard to find that even a shaman adheres to a general mode of thinking that belongs to modern *Homo*

sapiens. The formation of their cognition still follows the loop of: "**Observation – Hypothesis – Fitting (拟合) – Adjustment.**"

When these tribesmen see wind, rain, thunder, and lightning in their lives, or observe the proliferation and ultimate death of all things, they build concepts about the world based on this "observation." While primitive, it already possesses the capacity for imagination and structural construction that distinguishes humans from animals. When their environment changes, these primitive humans reshape their worldview in accordance with those changes, because their old theories can no longer fit the new observational results; thus, making adjustments is inevitable.

However, if a person lives long-term in today's Chinese society, they will easily realize that the modern Chinese populace has universally lost this capacity that distinguishes modern *Homo sapiens* from animals. First, they completely fail to observe from a self-centric perspective. Second, even after observing, they generate absolutely no associative connections. Third, they never use their own cognition to fit the information they receive. Finally, even when they blatantly discover that the facts they see contradict their original cognition, **they absolutely dare not negate their old views and reshape their cognition. They simply try every possible means to deceive themselves just to survive another day.**

If a foreign observer came to live in Chinese society long-term, one glaring characteristic they would feel is that the entire nation has become accustomed to "**meaninglessness**" (无意义).

Almost no one ponders what the world is like, why they are living, or what meaningful things they should do next. The fact is, the mental activities conducted by the majority of the population possess fundamentally no difference from those of wildebeests or lions on the African savanna—that is, they have lost the characteristics that can be called uniquely human.

The Chinese universally do not know how to attain deep inner joy and satisfaction because they fundamentally do not believe their lives possess any inherent meaning. Only comparison with others can stimulate them: even if they are living quite well themselves, seeing someone else living better makes them furiously resentful; **even if their own lives are miserable beyond words, seeing someone else suffering even more makes them deeply satisfied.**

This "pathological" (变态的) social condition is precisely the result of the long-term rule of a **bureaucratic state**. It does not even have a clear correlation with the level of socio-economic development, because we can easily find nations that are far poorer yet possess widespread religious faith.

Take Haiti, currently viewed as one of the most thoroughly failed states in governance. The vast majority of its population practices religions like Catholicism or Voodoo. This point alone is sufficient to distinguish Haitians from the wild animals of Africa, because no wild animal engages in activities like religious rituals.

But I fear the thought processes in the brains of the majority of Chinese people genuinely lack distinction from the animals of Africa—it boils down to nothing more than "*how do I survive today.*"

Therefore, rather than saying the Chinese people's worldview is flawed, it is more accurate to say that **the vast majority of Chinese people fundamentally do not possess a worldview at all.**

It is precisely this lack of common sense that renders the Chinese frequently incapable of making any effective judgments about the real world. Most fascinatingly, they lack even the most foundational concepts, such as the concept of historical development.

This might seem very strange to someone who does not live in China, but anyone who stays here for a while will feel this characteristic profoundly: **the Chinese believe that history is perpetually static**. If there is any change, it is nothing more than cyclical repetition over and over again.

Even though Marxism—the official state doctrine—fundamentally rejects this (advocating historical progression), this theory of perpetual stasis (持久不变论) overwhelmingly dominates the grassroots consciousness. When Chinese people consider the transition from one dynasty to another, you will rarely encounter even one or two individuals who realize what kind of structural social transformation has actually occurred!

For instance, when Chinese people talk about the concept of the "**dynastic cycle**" (历史周期律), they unthinkingly include some regimes prior to the Tang Dynasty in their consideration, namely the Han, Wei, and Jin.

However, if an observer uses even a single brain cell to think for just a second or two, it is not difficult to discover that the fall of these dynasties in classical China was precisely the result of **feudalization** (封建化). This is a fundamentally different matter from the complete collapse of social production under bureaucratic exploitation represented by the Tang, Song, Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, particularly the Ming.

The fall of the former is fundamentally no different from the fall of Rome. Could the **dynastic cycle** under a **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制) possibly apply to Rome or even European society? I am afraid anyone with a functioning brain would not think so.

If one insists on drawing a comparison with the **restoration-bureaucratic regimes** of **Late Imperial China** (中华帝国后期), perhaps the only somewhat meaningful example is the Byzantine Empire, which survived after the East-West division of Rome.

Because if we look at the duration of a dynasty's (or family's) rule, the "dynasties" of Byzantium were noticeably shorter than the lifespans of the dynasties in those European feudal states. This fact indeed corroborates, on another level, that during its existence, Byzantium possessed a nature similar to China's **restoration-bureaucratic states**—that is, the entire society was trapped in an anomalous bureaucratic state where **feudalization** had been interrupted.

Another highly ridiculous example is the continental expansionist policy implemented by Japan right at the beginning of the Meiji period.

When Japan had just begun its Restoration, although expansionist public opinion never ceased, the entire nation had not yet determined a specific strategic direction. There were even many Japanese scholars who believed that, faced with the steady encroachment of European imperialism dominated by Caucasians, the most urgent task was to unite with neighboring countries of the same race with long histories of interaction—like China and Korea—to resist the West together.

This idea was not necessarily bad. But the Japanese at that time obviously could not have realized that these two fantasized allies possessed absolutely zero possibility of spontaneously embarking on the path to modernization.

Thus, 20 years after the Restoration, the Japanese finally abandoned this unrealistic idea and adopted an extremely realistic strategy: Since the incompetence of China and Korea was beyond doubt, rather than waiting for them to be carved up by Western powers—which would leave Japan even more isolated—it would be better to leverage geographical advantages and strike first! After all, one cannot just sit back and watch others eat the meat.

For those familiar with modern social justice, this example will not cause cognitive dissonance (though it might feel somewhat awkward). But for the Chinese, it is entirely different. Because they will quickly realize that the Japanese mindset is immensely praised within traditional Chinese culture!

The absolute proof of this is that the famous "*Longzhong Plan*" (《隆中对》) presented by Zhuge Liang to Liu Bei (*a legendary blueprint for conquest during the Three Kingdoms period*) is fundamentally, substantively no different from Japan's continental expansionist policy!

Their foundational premise is identical: *forces that should not be provoked must be avoided for now; forces that have already been confirmed as useless garbage must be rapidly annexed. If you don't annex them, someone else will anyway, and ultimately, you will be the one who suffers.*

This cognitive dissonance occurs precisely because the Chinese generally do not understand concepts like the nation, state sovereignty, and international law—concepts that fully formed and gained widespread acceptance only over the last few centuries, that is to say, since the **early modern period** (近世).

After all, China never even finished the feudal stage; the **early modern period** is a social stage completely out of its reach!

The people's cognitive level is indeed virtually identical to that of the era of Liu Bei and Zhuge Liang. (*In fact, it should be slightly inferior, because during the late Eastern Han Dynasty of our country, **feudalization** was already very obvious, and the lord-vassal system among local warlords already existed*).

Therefore, once the issue of Japan's expansion during the Meiji period is brought up, Chinese people generally fall into an awkward dilemma where their left brain attacks their right brain. In the end, they can only gloss over the matter by displaying the most outstanding talent of our nation: "**playing dumb**" (装傻)—which, in a sense, means they are genuinely dumb!

Therefore, I once told my friends a joke: I said that since China has had emperors up to the present day, the most advanced ideology remains the Confucianism of the Han Dynasty.

This is because you could argue that Confucianism at that time was unscientific—before Newton, probably no one could definitively establish what science looked like. You could also argue that Confucianism at that time lacked logic; on this point, China inherently cannot compare with Greece and Rome.

But Han Dynasty Confucianism possessed one quality that left all the absurd doctrines that followed entirely in the dust: **it acknowledged common sense, and it did not shy away from the existence of problems.**

The one aspect where the Han Dynasty people far surpassed contemporary Chinese is that they were at least acutely aware of this basic common sense: **when bizarre occurrences frequently manifest in society, the entire nation has obviously gone down a wicked, aberrant path.**

Consequently, we can see that intellectuals of the Han, Wei, and Jin dynasties constantly used exaggerated phenomena to warn the populace. Resurrections of the dead, animals transforming into humans, or stones speaking—such things certainly do not exist. However, the fundamental concept that Han philosophy intended to convey was unequivocally correct.

Just like the *Song of the Bizarre* (《古怪歌》) and numerous bureaucratic satires from the late Qing Dynasty: if everyone feels that there is something fundamentally wrong with society, then the state has naturally plunged into some extremely severe crisis.

Such a principle—so glaringly obvious that one hardly knows how to further explain it—is actually a fact universally unrecognized by the commoners in China today.

During the summer vacation of 2023, I increasingly realized that for a nation to achieve good governance, it does not demand its citizens to possess profound or abundant knowledge; **it is entirely sufficient for them to merely possess the most basic common sense about the world.** Did Thomas Paine perhaps think the exact same way back then?

Yet, such an utterly simple demand is hopelessly out of reach for so many nations!

This is equally one of the reasons I believe it is necessary to record the things I have discovered. Even though the East Asian region, where China is located, has never been the mainstream of human civilizational development in any historical period, China is absolutely not an insignificant actor on the international stage. It is no exaggeration to say that its history throughout the BCE era was magnificent.

The collapse of this nation and its people will sound a terrifying alarm for the entire world: **Humanity spent millennia domesticating countless plants and animals, but the Chinese rulers spent a mere ten centuries domesticating humans.**

"Humans can be domesticated, and human intelligence can be obliterated."

This is the most profound lesson that China's tragic history leaves for posterity. Today, countries like the UK, the US, France, Germany, and Japan can be considered the vanguard of the realm. But who can guarantee that these nations, having achieved such monumental merits, are completely immune to making mistakes in the future?

Past experience, if not forgotten, serves as a guide for the future. (前事不忘，后事之师。)

3, 对于公民社会来说, 最重要的是人民应具有基本的常识

我认为这是因为中国人缺乏“常识”，这是一个非常有趣的问题。中国人缺乏知识吗？其实并不缺，中国的义务教育普及情况在全世界算是很不错的，对于城市的中产阶级（如果真的算的话）其人均学历已经相当可观。但是中国的教育妙就妙在这里，它确实会教给学生一些在生活中几乎用不到的专业知识，却绝对不会告诉你在生活中就可以广泛并且帮助人们立刻做出是非判断的常识，官方的教育一定会想方设法地误导受教育者。实际上中国人的常识是非常奇怪的，如果一个人在中国长期居住，就不难发现下意识在我国人民中是如此普遍并且难以受到质疑：统一总是优于分裂，不管付出什么代价，不管统一究竟带来的是社会的进步还是退步；主权高于人权，完全不知道主权在民的概念，认为一个国家的政府无论犯下多么严重的反人类暴行其他国家都没有任何理由干涉；强权胜过公理，明明我国政府在国际上是一副只会抗议的样子，中国的老百姓却依然相信，只要国家强大就可以随意破坏国际准则…

当然我举上述这三个政治性的观念已经是很给我国人民面子了，这些观点虽然说是 **wrong**，但是至少不是 **not even wrong**。而绝大部分中国人的观念的确是根本不知道怎么评价，比如天天都是朝廷下大棋，海量数据精确计算这种即使在汉语母语者听来都属于满纸荒唐言的怪话，如果是外国人去看那就更加不知所云了。根据我本人常年在中国生活的观察，现在中国人平均认识水平在全世界 200 多个国家和地区里恐怕处于倒数水平，甚至可以认为比那些尚且处于狩猎阶段的原始部落更等而下之。这是因为经过长达十个多世纪的复辟官僚统治之后中国人已经普遍丧失了那些可以称为“人类的智能”的能力，他们的大脑普遍没办法建立哪怕事物间最基本的逻辑联系，这是一件极为令人称奇的事。比如我们观察北方针叶林地区活动的部落民，就不难发现即使是萨满也遵从一般的，属于现代智人的思考方式，他们认识的形成仍然是“观测—猜想—拟合—调整”的。这些部落民在他们的生活中看到风雨雷电，万物繁衍最终死亡，就基于这种“观察”建立起了对世界虽然称得上原始，但是已经具备与动物相区别的想象和构建能力的观念。当他们身处的环境发生变化时，原始人又会随着这种变化而重塑自己的世界观，这是因为他们旧有的理论已经难以拟合新的观察结果，因此做出调整是必然的。

但是如果一个人在今天中国社会长期生活，他就不难意识到当今的中国百姓已经普遍失去了这种作为现代智人与动物相分别的能力，首先他们完全不会以自我为中心进行观察，其次观察完了也不会进行任何联想，接着从来不会用自己的认识去拟合获得的信息，最后即使明明发现自己看到的事实与原本的认知不符，却完全不敢去进行否定和认识重塑，只是想尽办法欺骗自己以求又过一日。如果一个外国观察者来到中国社会长期生活，他所能感受到的一个明显的特征就是整个国家已经习惯了“无意义”，几乎没有人去思考这个世界是什么样子，为什么要生活，接下来要做什么有意义的事情，事实就是大部分人口所能进行的思维活动跟非洲草原上的角马或者狮子本质上缺少区别，也就是失去了能够被称之为独属于人的特征。中国人普遍不知道自己应该如何获得内心深处的愉悦和满足，因为他们自己也不认为自己的生命有什么意义可言，只有与其他人的比较能让他们感到兴奋：即使自己过得也不错，但是看到别人比自己过得更好就恼火不已；即使自己过得已经惨不忍睹，但是看到别人过得更艰难就心满意足。

像这种“变态的”社会情况恰恰是官僚国家长期统治的结果，甚至与社会经济水平都没有明显的关系，因为我们明显能够找到一些较为贫穷的国家但是宗教信仰却十分普遍。就拿现在被视为治理最失败的国家之一的海地来说，绝大部分人口信仰天主教，巫毒教这样的宗教，光这一点就足以把海地人跟非洲的野生动物相区分，因为没有哪个野生动物会做出参与宗教仪式这种活动。但是恐怕大部分中国人大脑中的思考确实跟非洲的动物缺少区别，无非是怎么活过今天罢了。因此我们与其说中国人的世界观是错误的，不如说绝大多数中国人并不存在世界观。恰恰是常识的缺乏使得中国人往往无法对于现实世界进行任何有效的判断，最有意思的是，他们甚至连一些基本的观念都没有，比如历史发展的概念。这一点对于不在中国生活的人来说可能很奇怪，不过只要待上一段时间就会很深刻地感受到该特征，中国人认为历史是长久不变的，如果说变那不过是循环一次又一次，哪怕作为官方学说的马克思主义根本也不承认这一点，但是这种持久不变论在民间几乎占据了压倒性的主流。当中国人考虑一个朝代和另一个朝代的时候，你几乎极少看到有那么哪怕一个两个人意识到社会经历了什么样的变迁。

例如当中国人在讲“历史周期律”这个概念的时候，他们会不假思索地把唐之前的一些政权加入考虑，即汉、魏和晋。可是只要观察者稍微用那么一丁点脑细胞去思考一两秒钟，就不难发现这几个古典中国的朝代的灭亡就是封建化带来的结果，与唐、宋、元、明、清特别是以明朝为代表的官僚剥削下社会生产完全崩溃是截然不同的两码事。前者的灭亡跟罗马本质上并没有区别，难道复辟官僚制下的历史周期律还能适用于罗马乃至欧洲社会吗？恐怕任何有脑子的人都不会这么想。如果非要与中华帝国后期的复辟官僚政权相对比，恐怕唯一有些意义的例子就是罗马东西分治之后残存的拜占庭帝国。因为如果从一个王朝（家族）统治的时间来看，拜占庭的“朝代”明显短于欧洲那些封建国家的王朝国祚，这个事实的确在另一个层面印证了拜占庭在它存在的时间具有与中国复辟官僚国家相似的性质，也就是整个社会处于封建化中断的官僚制异常状态。

还有一个非常可笑的例子是明治时期日本刚刚开始推行的扩张政策，当日本刚刚开始维新的时候，虽然扩张主义的舆论从来也没有停止过，但是整个国家并没有确定具体的战略方向。甚至有很多日本学者认为，面对白人为主的欧洲帝国主义步步紧逼的现状，当务之急是联合中国和朝鲜这样有长期交往史的，同一人种的邻国一起抗击西方。这个想法不可谓不好，但是当年的日本人显然不可能意识到这两个幻想中的盟国没有半点自发走上现代化道路的可能。于是在维新 20 年之后，日本人终于放弃了不切实际的想法，采取了极为现实主义的策略：既然中国和朝鲜的无能已经无需置疑，那么与其等着它们被

西方列强瓜分，以至于让日本更加孤立，不如凭借着地理上的优势先下手为强，总不能只看着别人吃肉吧！这个例子对于熟悉现代社会公义的人来说不至于造成思维错乱（虽然也可能感到别扭就是了），但是对于中国人来说就不一样，因为他们很快会意识到日本人的想法在中国传统文化里是受到极大赞扬的，证明就是，诸葛亮给刘备献上的《隆中对》实质与大陆扩张政策没有一点区别。它们的立足点都是，那些不该招惹的势力现在不能招惹，已经被确认是废物的势力就应该快速吞并，反正你不吞并总有别人吞并，到时候受害的还是自己。正是因为中国人普遍不了解民族，国家主权，国际法这些最近几个世纪，也就是说近世以来才完全形成并被广泛认同的概念，毕竟中国连封建阶段都没有走完，近世已然属于那种挨不着边的社会阶段了。人们的认识水平确实就跟刘备诸葛亮那个时候差不多（实际上应该还要略微不如，因为我国东汉后期封建化就已经十分明显，地方诸侯的主从制度已然存在），所以一旦说到明治时期日本扩张的问题，中国人就会普遍陷入左脑攻击右脑的尴尬境地，最后也只能通过发挥我们这个民族最为杰出的天赋，也就是“装傻”（某种意义上就是真傻）来把事情糊弄过去。

所以我曾经对朋友们说过一个笑话，我说中国自从有了皇帝到如今，最为先进的思想仍然是汉代的儒学。这是因为你可以说那个时候的儒学不科学，在牛顿之前大概也没有人能够确定科学是什么样，你也可以说那个时候的儒学缺少逻辑，这一点中国毕竟不能跟希腊和罗马相比。但是汉代的儒学有一点足以甩开之后的那些荒唐的学说，那就是它承认常识，并且毫不避讳问题的存在。汉朝人远远胜过当代中国人的一点是，他们至少很清楚这样一个常识，那就是当社会上怪事频发的时候，整个国家显然已经走上邪路了。于是我们可以看到汉魏晋的知识分子们总是用夸张的现象来警示人们，人死而复生，动物变成人，石头会说话这种事情固然不存在，但是汉代哲学想表达的基本观念是没错的。就如同清朝末年的《古怪歌》和许多官场小说一样，如果人人都觉得这个社会不对劲，那么国家当然陷入了某种极为严重的问题。就这么一个显而易见到简直让人不知道该怎么解释的道理，在今天中国却实实在在是一个老百姓普遍不知道的事实。在2023年暑假，我越来越意识到一个国家要想获得良好的治理，并不要求公民们需要有多么丰富的知识，他们只要有对于世界最基本的常识足矣了，托马斯潘恩当年会不会也这样想呢。可就是这样一个简单到不能再简单的诉求，又是多少国家望尘莫及的呢？这同样也是我认为有必要将自己所发现的事记录下来的原因之一，哪怕中国所在的东亚地区虽然在任何历史时期都不是人类文明发展的主流，但中国绝不是一个国际舞台上无足轻重的角色，在整个公元前的历史说辉煌也不为过。这个国家、民族的崩溃将给全世界敲响警钟：人类花了数千年驯化了无数动植物，而中国统治者仅用了十个世纪驯化了人。“人是可以被驯化的，人的智能是可以被抹杀的”，这就是中国惨剧一般的历史给后人留下最深刻的教训，今天像英美法德日这样的国家可以算是天下的先锋，可是谁又能打包票这些立下赫赫功勋的国家将来没有犯错的可能呢？前事不忘，后事之师。